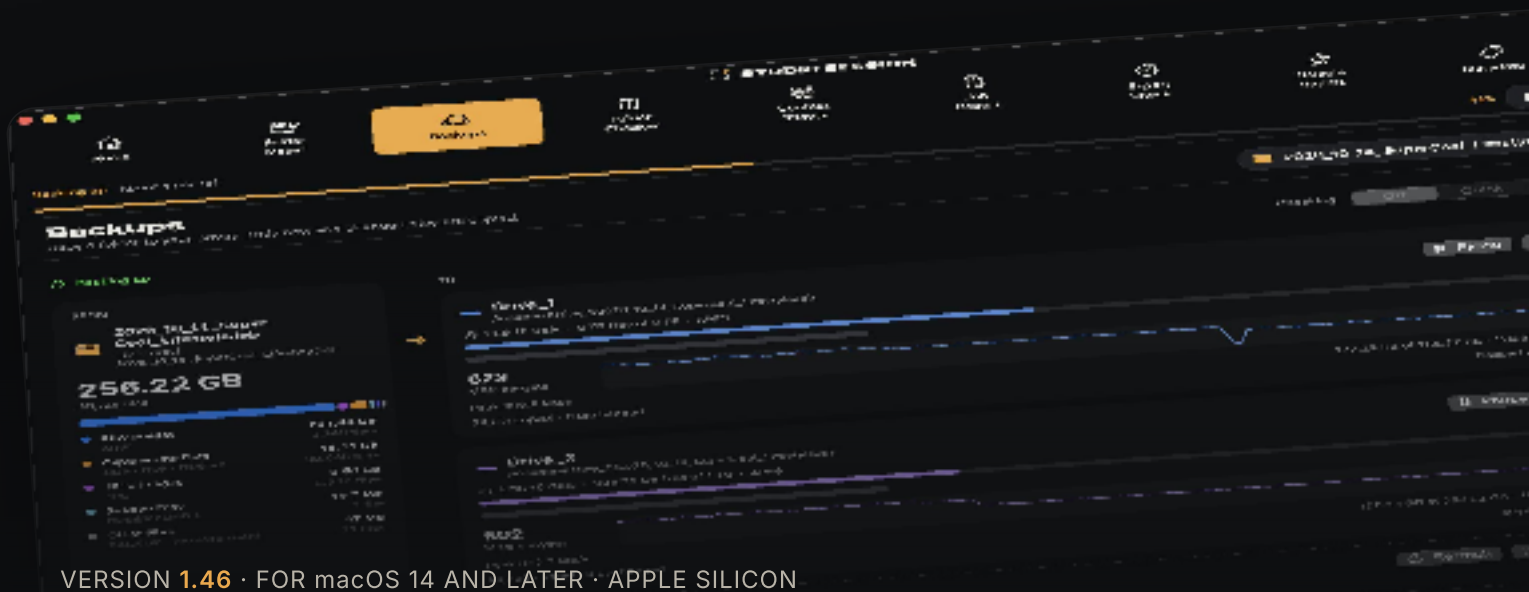
STUDIO SESSION

Complete Manual

Every tool and option, how the backups protect your work, and what to do when something goes wrong.

COMPLETE REFERENCE



VERSION 1.46 · FOR macOS 14 AND LATER · APPLE SILICON

CONTENTS

Inside this guide

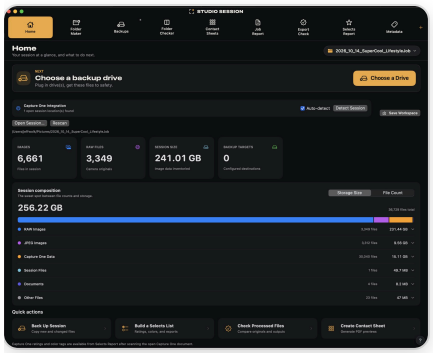
Studio Session is a Mac app for digital techs and photographers: it opens your Capture One session, backs it up to as many drives as you like, checks the copies, and helps you deliver.

01 Getting around
02 Home
03 Folder Maker
04 Set up a backup
05 Preview what will copy
06 While it copies
07 Backups in depth
08 Folder Checker
09 Contact Sheets
10 Job Report
11 Export Check
12 Selects Report
13 Metadata
14 A shoot day, start to finish
15 Customizing and settings
16 Troubleshooting

01 OVERVIEW

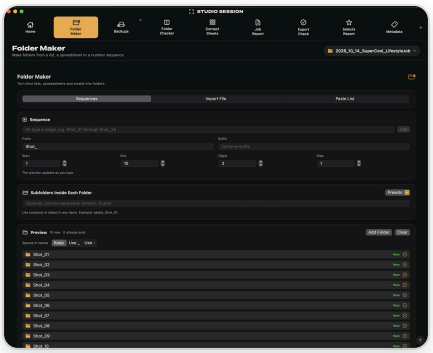
Getting around

Nine tools sit in tabs across the top. The session in use shows top right on every tab.



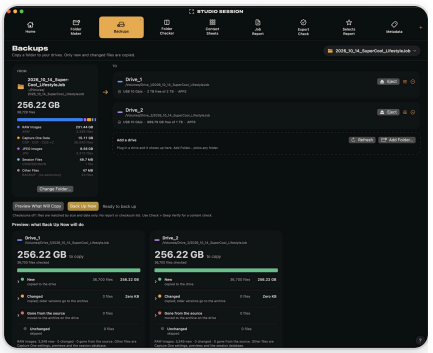
Home

Your session at a glance and the one thing to do next.



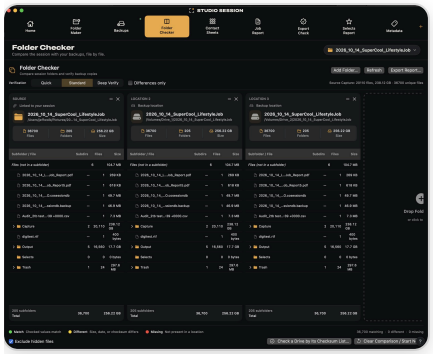
Folder Maker

Turn shot lists, spreadsheets and pictures of lists into folders.



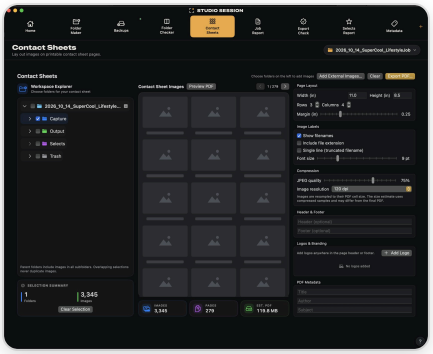
Backups

Copy the session to one or more drives. Only new and changed files are copied.



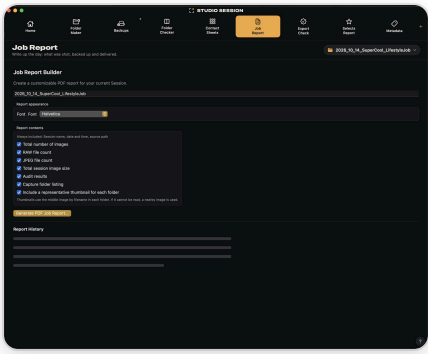
Folder Checker

Compare the session with its backups, file by file.



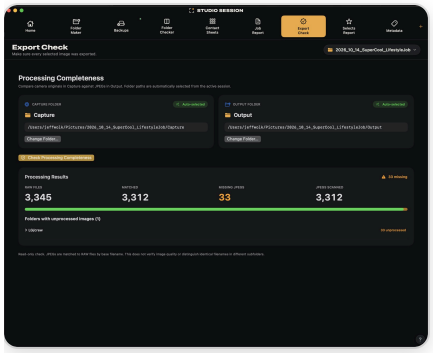
Contact Sheets

Lay images out on printable PDF pages.



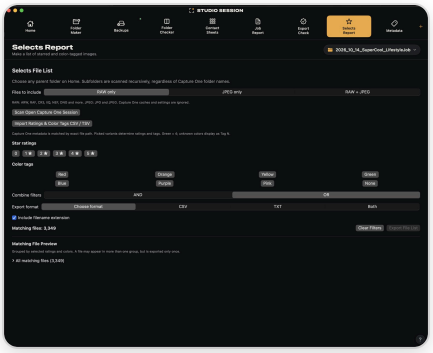
Job Report

A PDF write-up of what was shot, backed up and delivered.



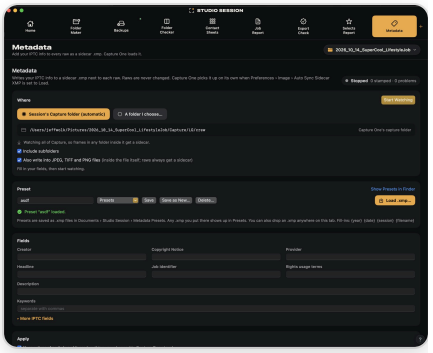
Export Check

Make sure every raw has an exported JPEG.



Selects Report

A file list of starred and color-tagged frames from Capture One.



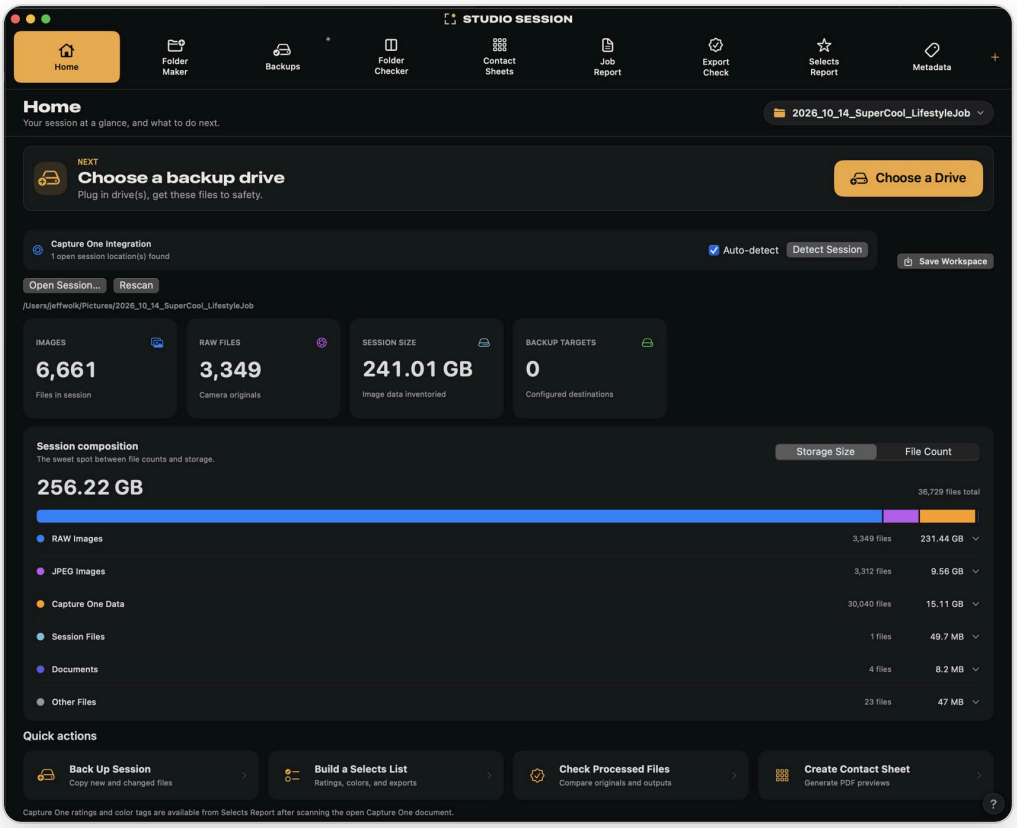
Metadata

Your IPTC info, written as a sidecar next to every raw as it lands.

02 HOME

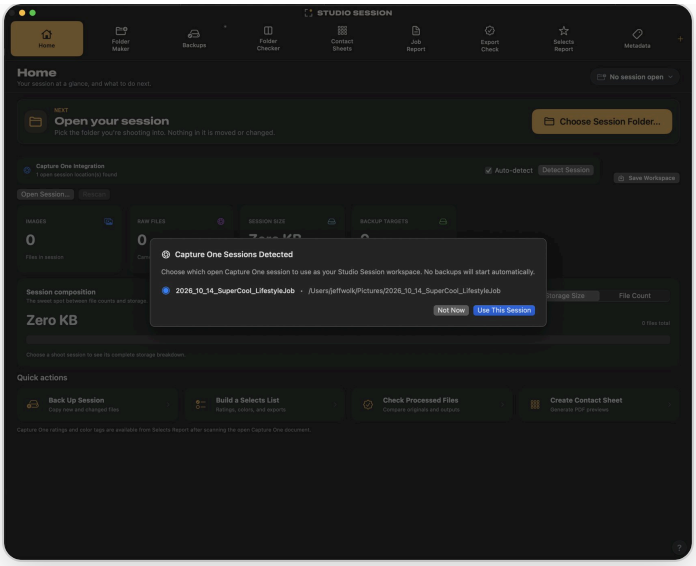
Home

Your session at a glance, and what to do next.



Home with a session open

1. Open Capture One with your session, or click **Choose Session Folder...** and pick the session folder.
2. If Capture One is open, a dialog lists the sessions it has open. Pick one and click **Use This Session**. Nothing starts on its own.
3. Follow the **NEXT** card at the top. It always shows the one thing to do next, for example **Choose a Drive**.



Capture One sessions are found for you. Not Now leaves everything as it is.

What you see

- **Images, Raw files, Session size, Backup targets:** a quick count of the session and how many drives it backs up to.
- **Session composition:** where the space goes (RAW, JPEG, Capture One data, documents and more). Switch between **Storage Size** and **File Count**.
- **Quick actions:** one click to Back Up Session, Build a Selects List, Check Processed Files or Create Contact Sheet.
- **Capture One Integration:** with **Auto-detect** on, Studio Session notices when Capture One opens a session. **Detect Session** looks again right away.
- **Session chip** (top right on every tab): shows the session in use; click it to switch.
- **Open Session… / Rescan:** pick a session by hand, or count it again after big changes.
- **Save Workspace:** saves your session, backup folders and options to a file you can reopen later.

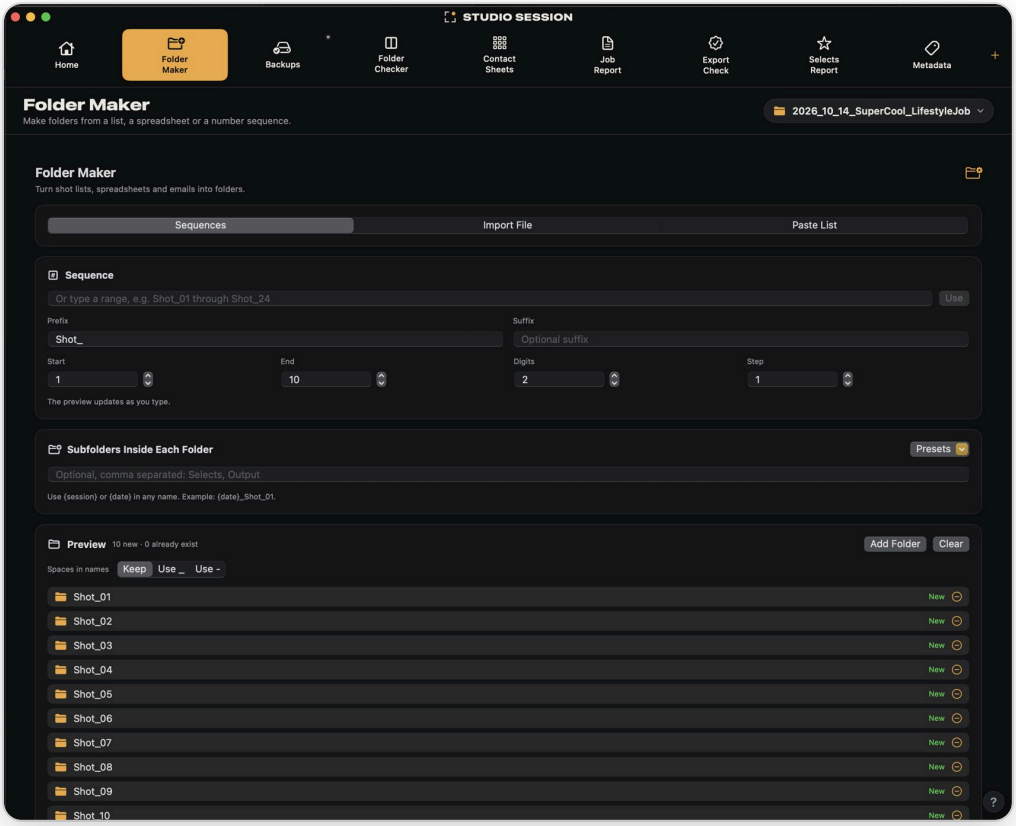
GOOD TO KNOW

Opening a session never moves, renames or changes anything in it.

03 FOLDER MAKER

Folder Maker

Make folders from a list, a spreadsheet or a number sequence.



Folder Maker with a ten-shot sequence ready to create

Three ways to make a list

METHOD	HOW IT WORKS
Sequences	Prefix, start, end, digits and step, for example Shot_01 to Shot_24. Or type a range in plain words and click **Use**. The preview updates as you type.
Import File	Choose an Excel (.xlsx), CSV or TSV file, then click a column. Each cell becomes a folder; blank cells are skipped. Pick the sheet and whether the first row is a header.
Paste List	One folder per line. Use / for subfolders, for example Look 1/Selects. Paste text, or click **Read a Picture...** for a photo or screenshot of a shot list. The text is read on your Mac.

1. Build the list with one of the three methods.
2. Optional: under **Subfolders Inside Each Folder**, add folders to create inside each one (comma separated), or pick a saved preset.

3. Check the preview. Each row says **New** or that it already exists. Remove a row with its minus button.
4. Choose where to create them: Session, Capture, Output or a folder you choose.
5. Click **Create** and confirm.

More options

- **Fill-ins:** use {session} or {date} in any name, for example {date}_Shot_01.
- **Spaces in names:** **Keep**, **Use _** or **Use -**, applied to every level. The preview shows the new name beside any it changes.
- **Paste List cleanup:** **Remove bullets and numbers** and **Split commas** tidy lists copied from emails.
- **More than one place:** Command-click Session, Capture or Output to create the same folders in each.
- **Undo Last Creation** takes back the folders you just made; **Show in Finder** opens them.
- **Presets:** **Save Current as Preset** keeps a subfolder set for next time.

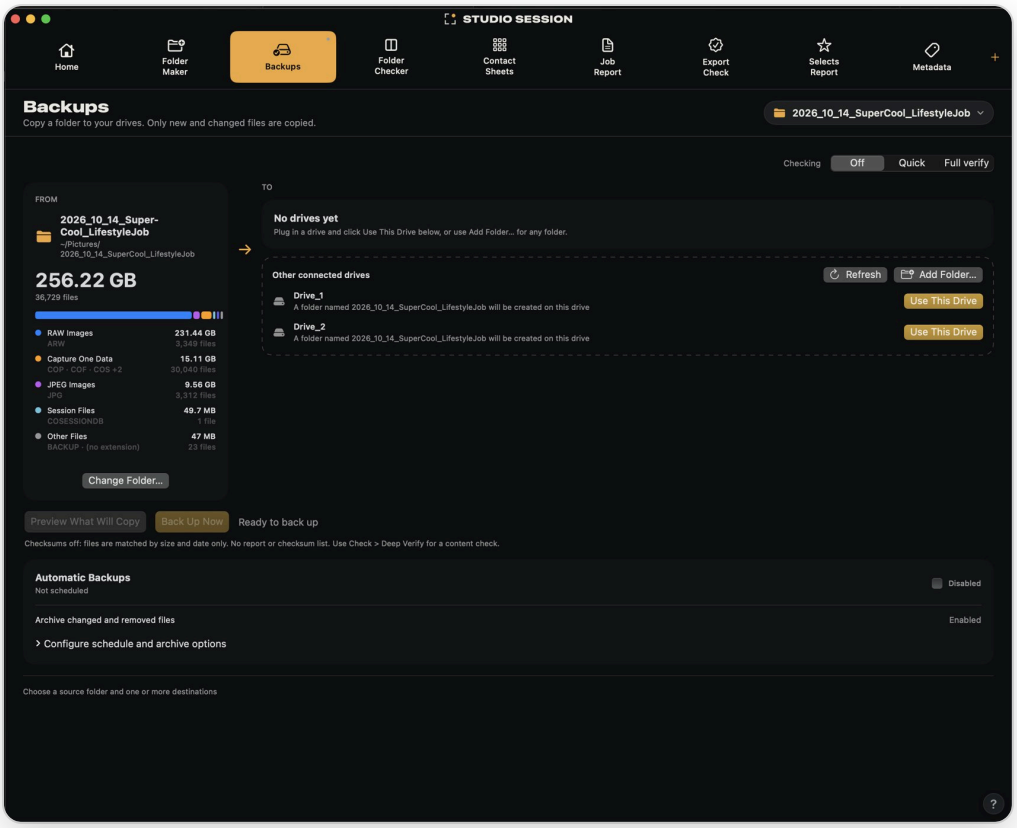
GOOD TO KNOW

Folders that already exist are left alone. Folder Maker only ever adds folders.

04 BACKUPS

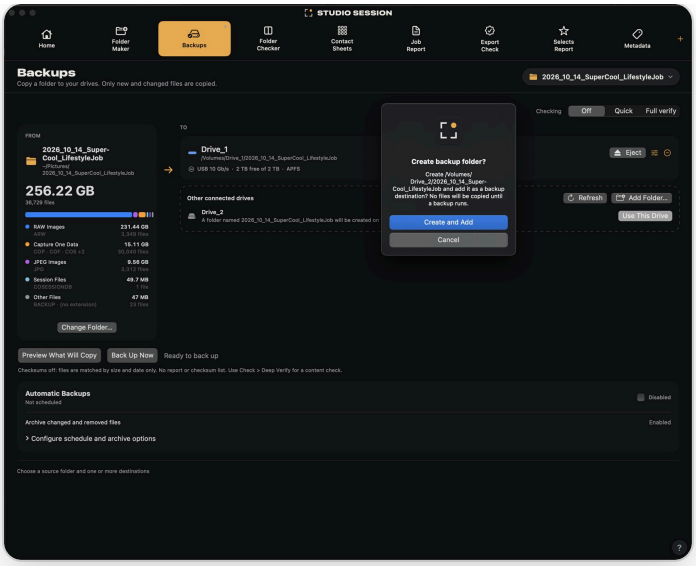
Set up a backup

Choose what to back up, where to, and how carefully to check it.



A source on the left; connected drives waiting on the right

1. Check the **FROM** card. It shows the folder being backed up, its size and what is in it. To back up a different folder, click **Change Folder...** or drop a folder on the card. Any folder works, not only Capture One sessions.
2. Plug in your drives. They appear under **Other connected drives**. Click **Use This Drive** and confirm **Create and Add**. If the drive already has a matching folder, it is used as is.
3. Pick **Checking** at the top: **Off**, **Quick** or **Full verify** (see the table below).
4. Optional: click **Preview What Will Copy** to see exactly what will be copied before anything is written.
5. Click **Back Up Now**.



Use This Drive asks before it creates the backup folder

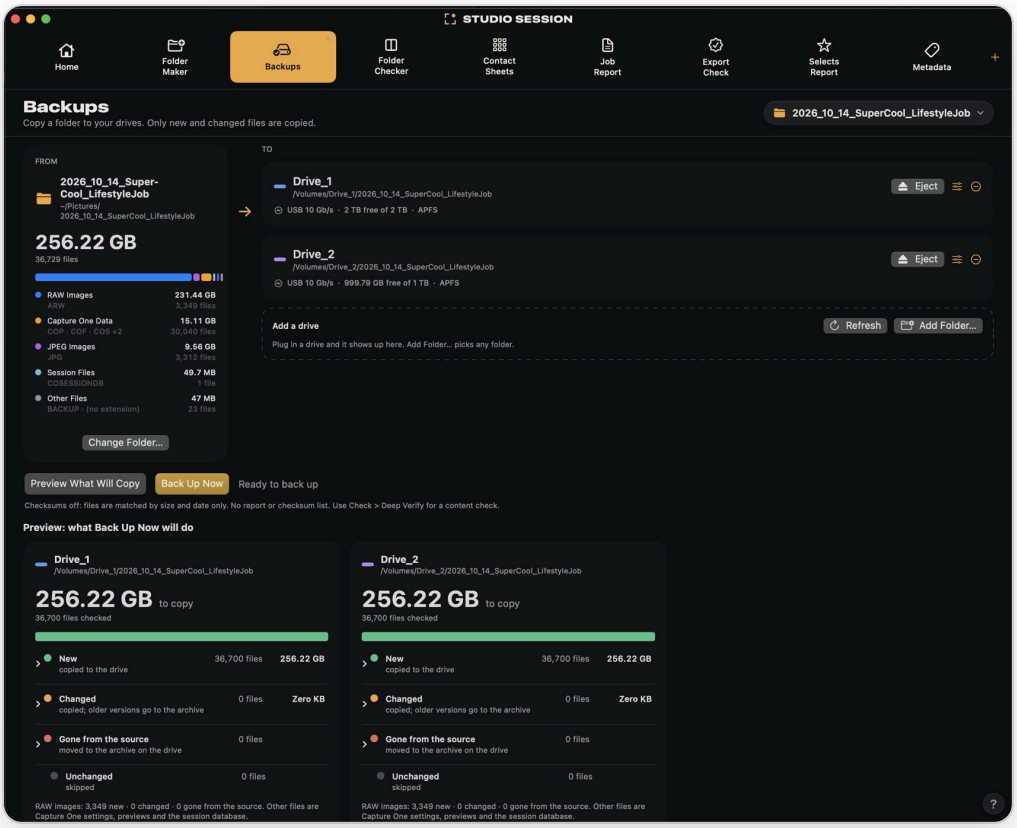
- **Add Folder…** picks any folder on any drive.
- Each drive card shows its link speed, free space and format, plus the last backup.
- Card buttons: **Eject** (safe to unplug), the sliders icon (what to leave out on this drive, including hidden files) and the minus (stop using this drive; nothing on it is deleted).

How carefully to check

CHECKING	WHAT IT DOES	WHEN TO USE IT
Off	Files are matched by size and date only. No report or checksum list.	Quick top-ups when speed is all that matters.
Quick	Each original gets an xxHash64 checksum while it copies, about as fast as Off. Copies are not read back.	The every-few-minutes backups during a shoot.
Full verify	Copies everything, then reads every copy back from the drive and compares it with the original. A copy that does not match is copied again.	The wrap-up backup at the end of the day. The safest.

Preview what will copy

See what Back Up Now will do on each drive before it does it.



Preview: one card per drive, filled in as soon as each drive is checked

- The big number is how much will be copied to that drive.
- The bar and rows split the files into **New**, **Changed**, **Gone from the source** and **Unchanged**.
- Open a row to see the folders involved, with counts and sizes; open a folder to see every file. Capture One previews and settings sit in their own drawer inside each folder.

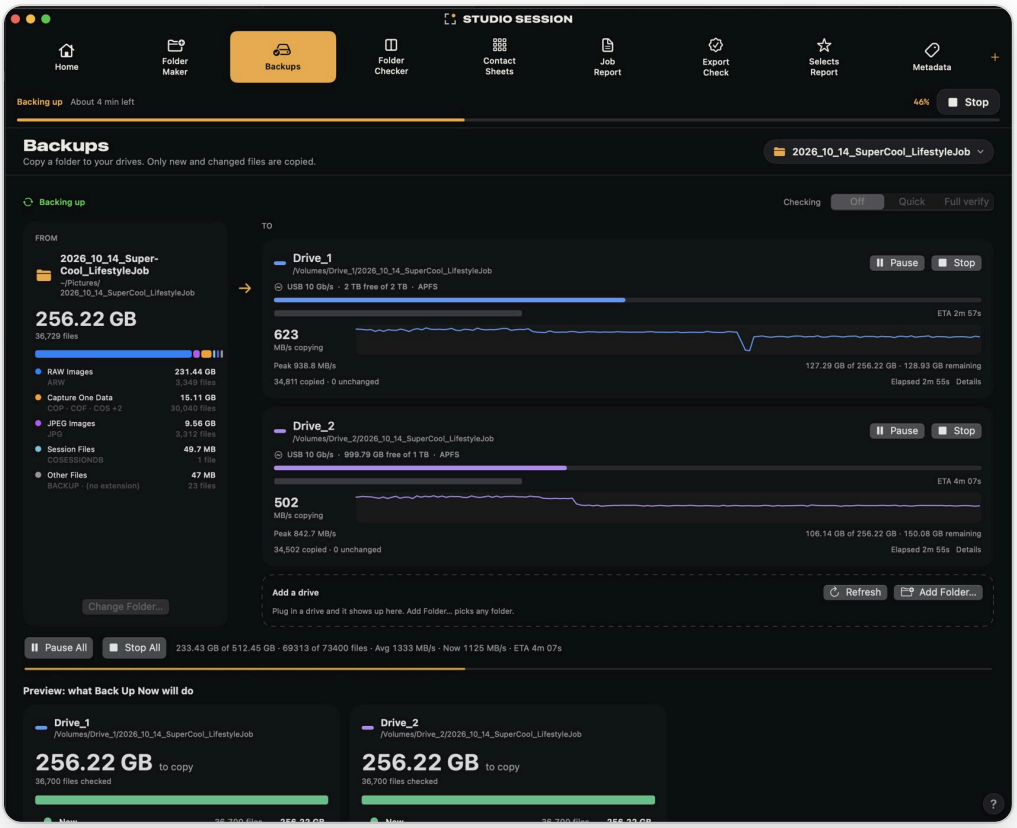
GOOD TO KNOW

A preview only reads. Nothing on the drives is changed.

06 BACKUPS

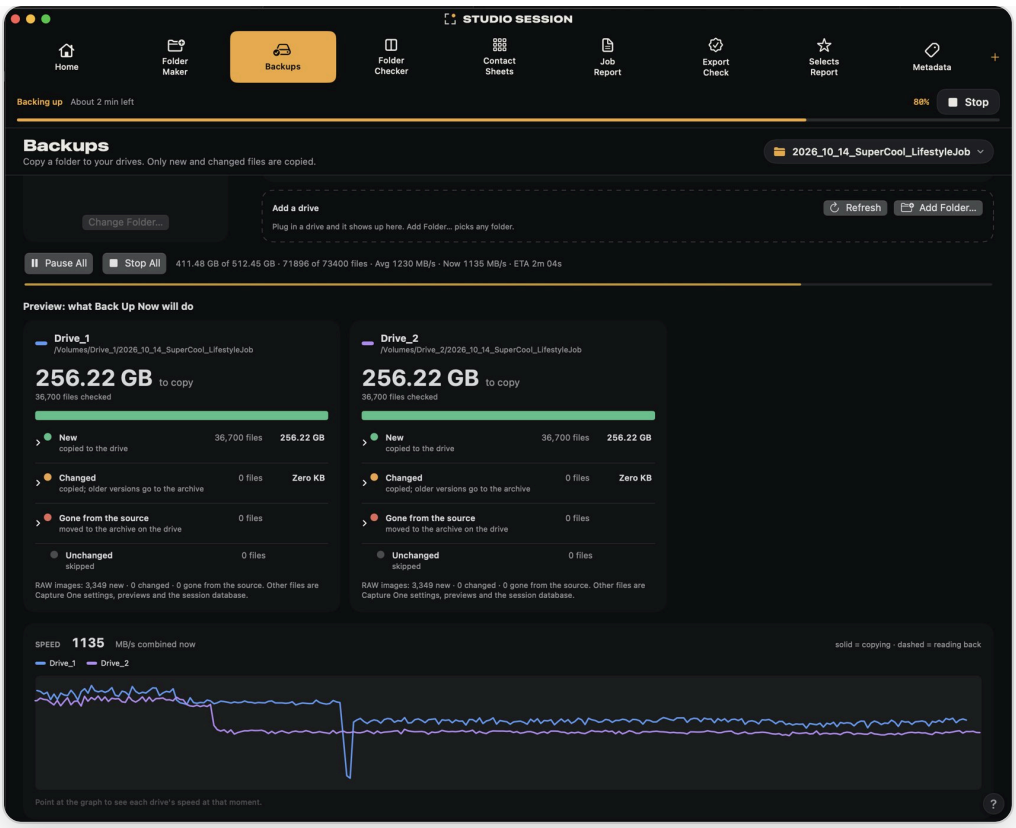
While it copies

Every drive's progress and speed, live.



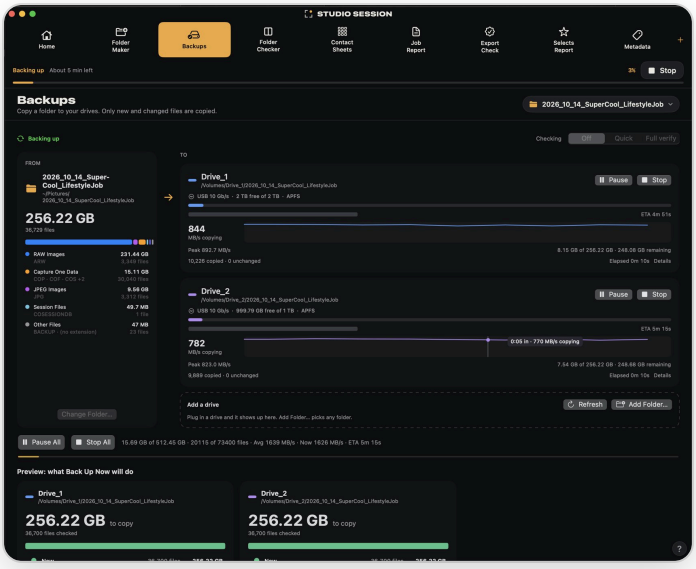
Two drives copying at once, each in its own color

- Each drive has its own color, used for its bar and its speed lines.
- Each card shows its live speed, time left and its own **Pause** and **Stop**. Pausing or stopping one drive leaves the others running.
- **Pause All** and **Stop All** act on every drive. The strip under the tabs keeps the backup in view on any tab.
- Up to four drives copy at once; more wait their turn. A drive added mid-backup joins in.



The speed graph: one line per drive. Solid while copying, dashed while reading back.

Point at the graph to see each drive's speed at that exact moment.



Pointing at a drive's own speed line shows its speed at that moment

WHEN IT FINISHES

Each card reads **Up to date**. With Quick or Full verify, **Open Backup Report** opens the record on the drive. If a backup fails, a dialog you must click appears and the Dock icon bounces, so it can't be missed.

07 BACKUPS

Backups in depth

Schedules, the archive, safety checks and what happens when things go wrong.

Automatic backups

Turn on **Automatic Backups** and set how many minutes apart. Backups run while Studio Session is open, only copy what changed, and never stop to ask questions. Quick checking suits a schedule; run a Full verify at wrap.

The archive: nothing is thrown away

With **Archive changed and removed files** on (the default), the older version of a changed file and any file that left the session are moved into **_StudioSession_Archive** on the drive, in a dated folder (Replaced, Removed from source). The card shows the archive size; **Clear...** empties it after you confirm. An option can trim the oldest archived copies when a drive runs low.

Files renamed in Capture One are recognized and renamed on the backup instead of copied again.

Safety checks before anything changes

CHECK	WHAT HAPPENS
Wrong folder	If the backup folder on a drive holds a backup of a different folder, you're asked **Folder names don't match. Continue?** Cancel is the default.
Many files gone	If the source is empty, or more than 50 files and more than a quarter of what's backed up have left the source, that drive is held with nothing changed. You're asked whether to move them to the archive. Cancel is the default.
Drive format	Drives that aren't APFS get a one-time note (HFS+ and exFAT work, APFS is fastest and most reliable for SSDs).
Slow link	A drive on a slow USB connection is pointed out before you start.
Permissions	If a drive can't be written to, **Fix Permissions** offers to fix it (macOS asks for your password).

Reports and checksums on the drive

With Quick or Full verify, each drive gets **_StudioSession_Reports** with a checksum list (Checksums.xxh64) and a report for each run that copied something. **Clear History...** deletes old reports only; the checksum list stays.

When something goes wrong

SITUATION	WHAT STUDIO SESSION DOES
A file is still being written	Capture One may still be saving a frame. That file is skipped (amber note) and picked up on the next run. A changing file is never copied.
A file can't be read or is locked	That file is skipped and listed in red with the reason; everything else is backed up.
Drive unplugged mid-backup	Nothing half-written is left as a real file. Plug it back in and click Back Up Now: it carries on, and copies that weren't read back yet are checked first.
Stopped during the read-back	The next backup reads the unchecked copies back first ("earlier verified").

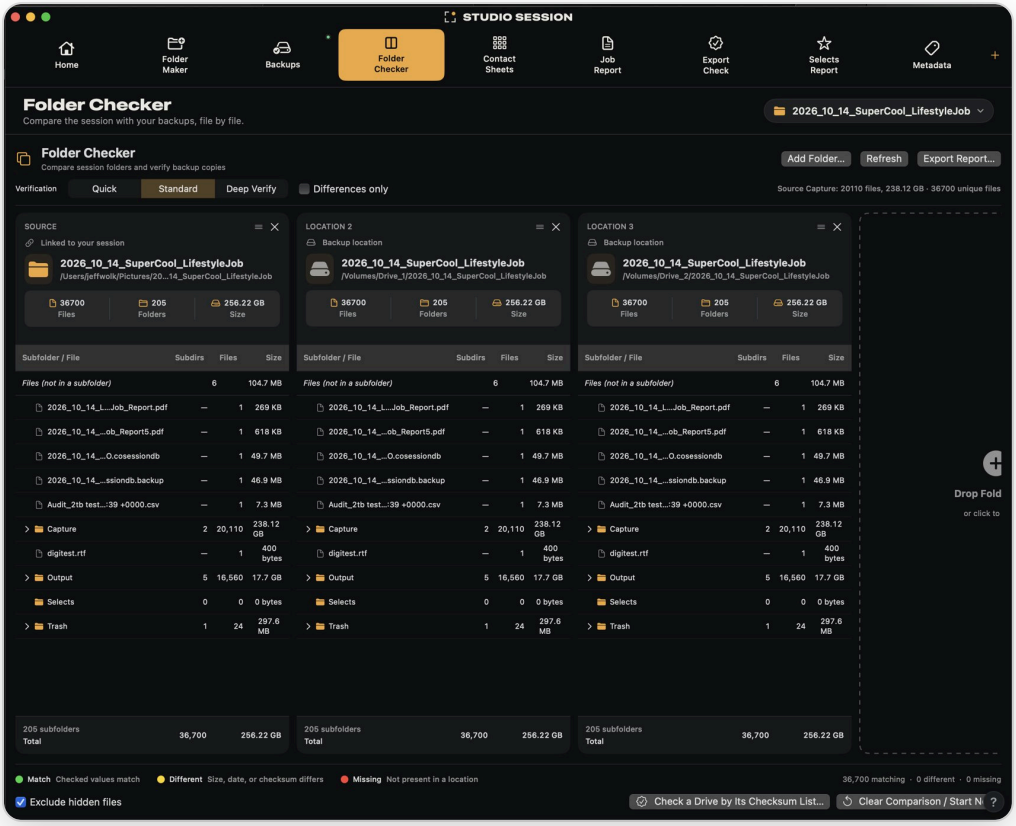
BEFORE YOU UNPLUG

Wait for **Up to date**, then click **Eject**. Studio Session also flushes each drive before it says Up to date.

08 FOLDER CHECKER

Folder Checker

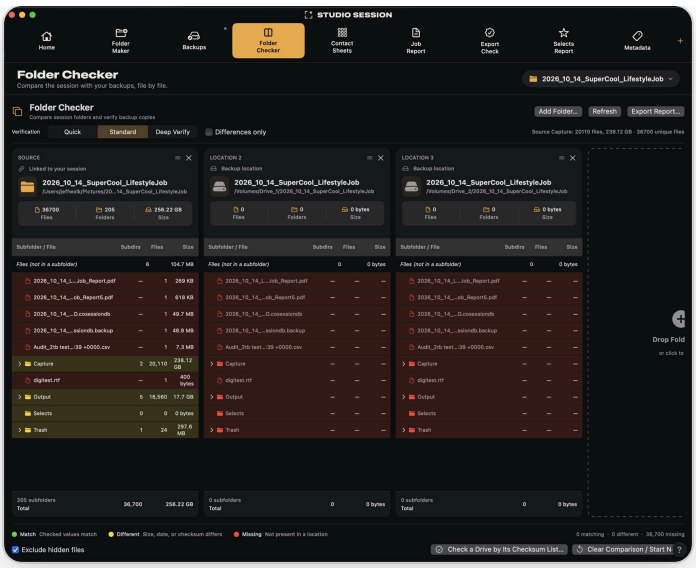
Compare the session with your backups, file by file.



Three locations, every file matching

1. Open Folder Checker. Your session (source) and your backup folders are added for you. **Add Folder...** adds any other folder, or drop one on the empty column.
2. Pick a **Verification**: **Quick**, **Standard** or **Deep Verify**. Clicking one runs it.
3. Read the colors: green match, amber different, red missing. Turn on **Differences only** to hide everything that matches.

MODE	COMPARES
Quick	File names and sizes. Fastest.
Standard	Names, sizes and dates (2-second tolerance).
Deep Verify	Reads every file and compares SHA-256 hashes. Slowest; catches same-size content changes.



Before the backup: everything on the drives shows as missing (red)

- While a backup runs, Folder Checker waits and then checks automatically when it finishes (Quick and Standard).
- **Check a Drive by Its Checksum List...** checks a Studio Session backup against the checksums saved when it was made. The original session isn't needed.
- **Export Report...** saves the comparison; **Clear Comparison** starts over.
- **Exclude hidden files** ignores files like .DS_Store.

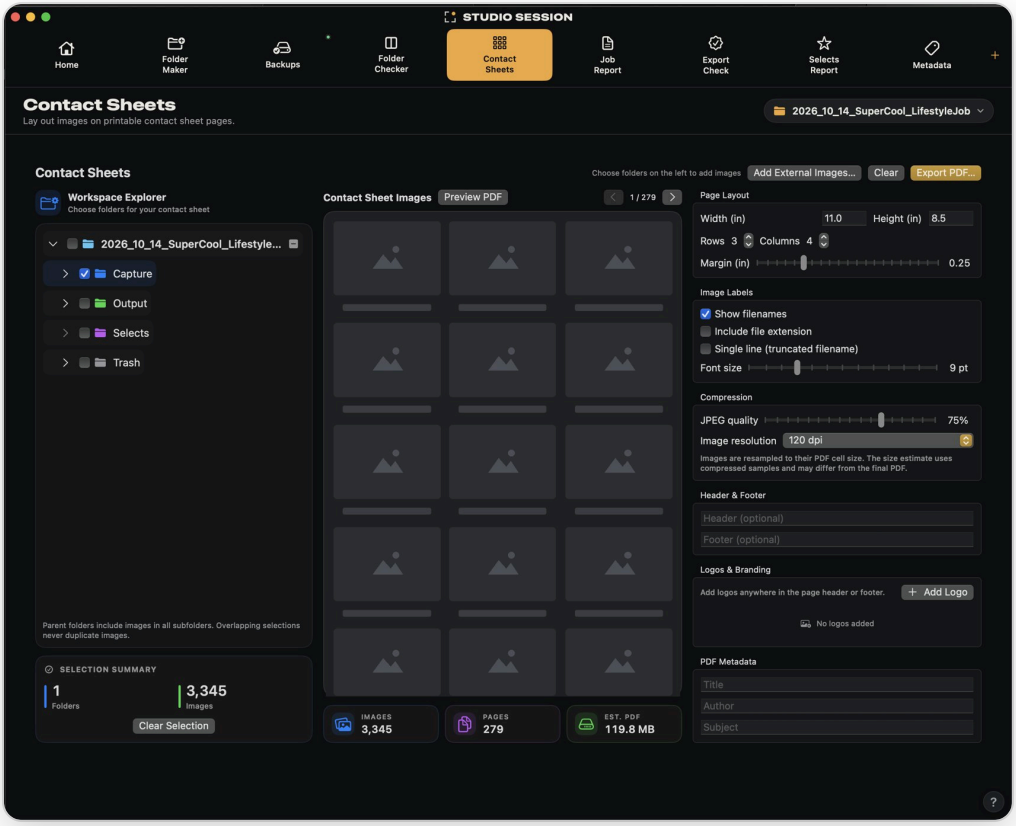
GOOD TO KNOW

Folder Checker only reads. It never changes a file.

09 CONTACT SHEETS

Contact Sheets

Lay out images on printable contact sheet pages.



Contact Sheets (images hidden for this guide)

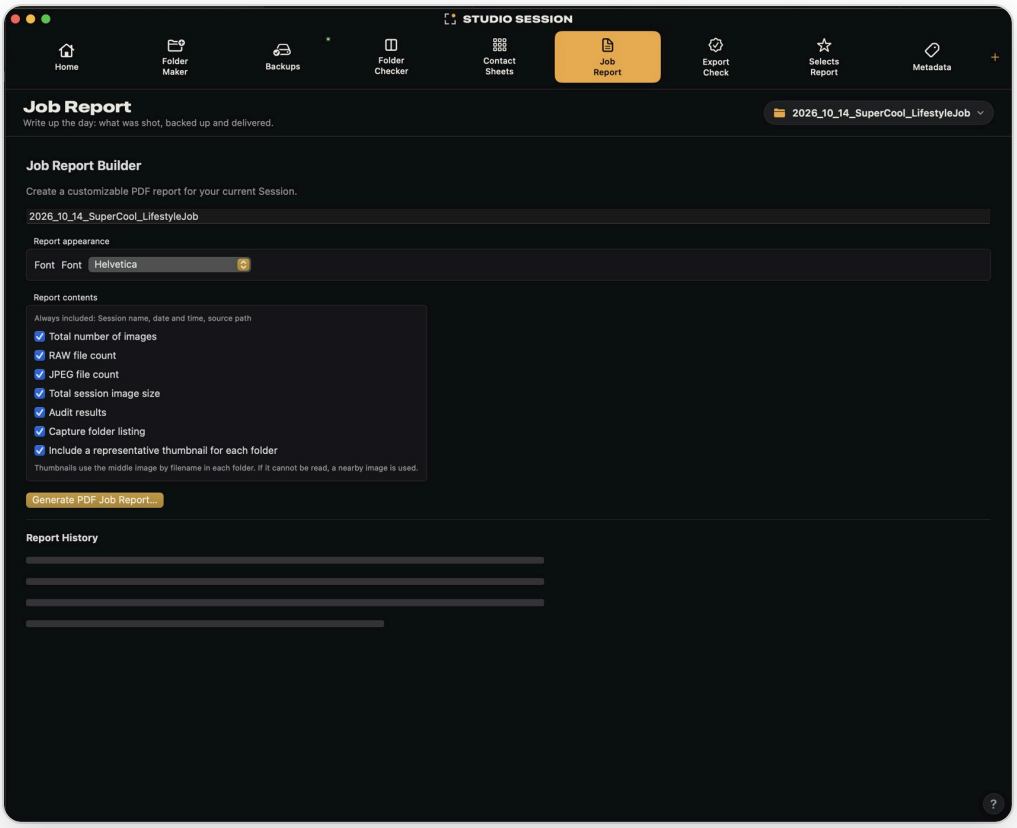
1. Tick folders in **Workspace Explorer**. A parent folder includes all its subfolders; an image is never added twice. **Add External Images...** adds images from anywhere.
2. Set the page: width and height in inches, rows, columns and margin.
3. Choose labels: filenames, extensions, one line, font size.
4. Click **Preview PDF** to page through it, then **Export PDF...**.

- **Compression:** JPEG quality and image resolution (72 to 300 dpi). The estimated PDF size is shown under the preview.
- **Header and footer:** optional text on every page.
- **Logos:** **Add Logo** places your logo in the header or footer; set its width and whether it shows on the first page only.
- **PDF metadata:** title, author and subject saved in the PDF.

10 JOB REPORT

Job Report

Write up the day: what was shot, backed up and delivered.



Job Report (report history hidden for this guide)

1. Check the report name (it starts as the session name) and pick a font.
2. Tick what to include: image totals, RAW and JPEG counts, session size, audit results and the Capture folder listing. Session name, date and source path are always included.
3. Optional: a thumbnail for each folder.
4. Click **Generate PDF Job Report...** and choose where to save it.

THUMBNAILS

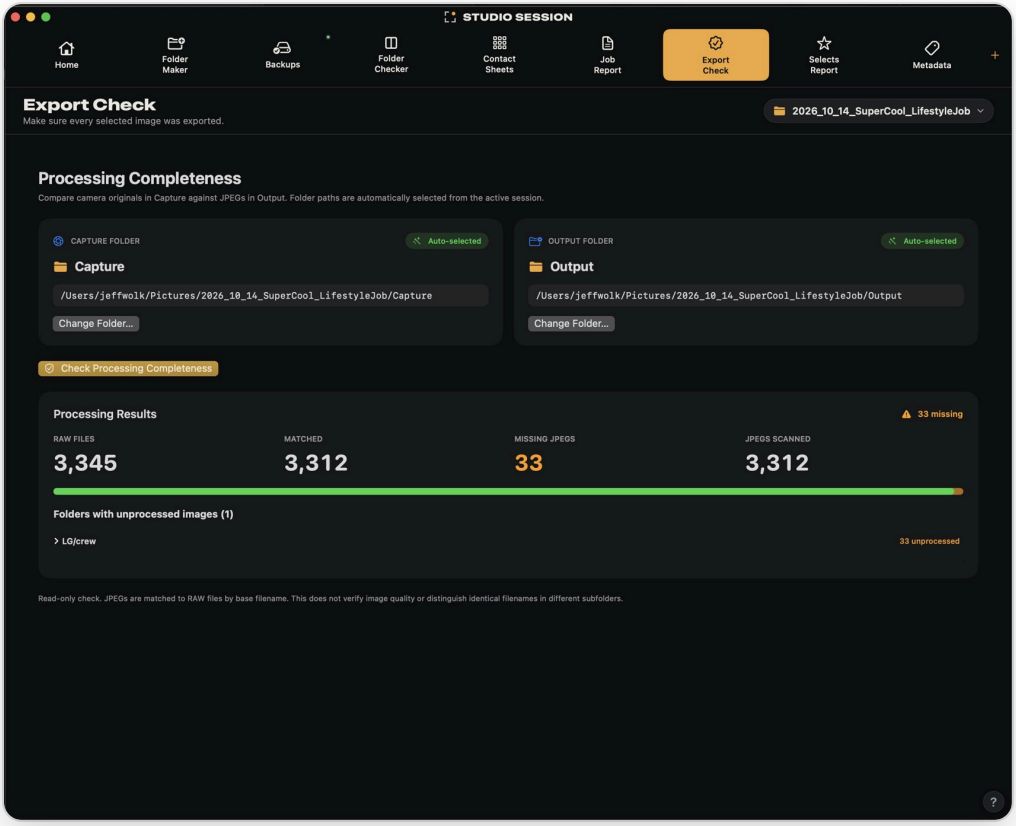
Each folder uses its middle image by filename. If a graded JPEG with the same name is in Output (for example from a quick proof export), that is used; otherwise the raw's built-in preview.

Report History lists earlier reports and where they were saved.

11 EXPORT CHECK

Export Check

Make sure every selected image was exported.



Export Check: 33 raws in one folder have no JPEG yet

1. The Capture and Output folders are picked from your session (**Auto-selected**). Use **Change Folder...** to pick others.
2. Click **Check Processing Completeness** .
3. Read the totals (RAW files, matched, missing JPEGs, JPEGs scanned) and open **Folders with unprocessed images** to see which frames still need exporting.

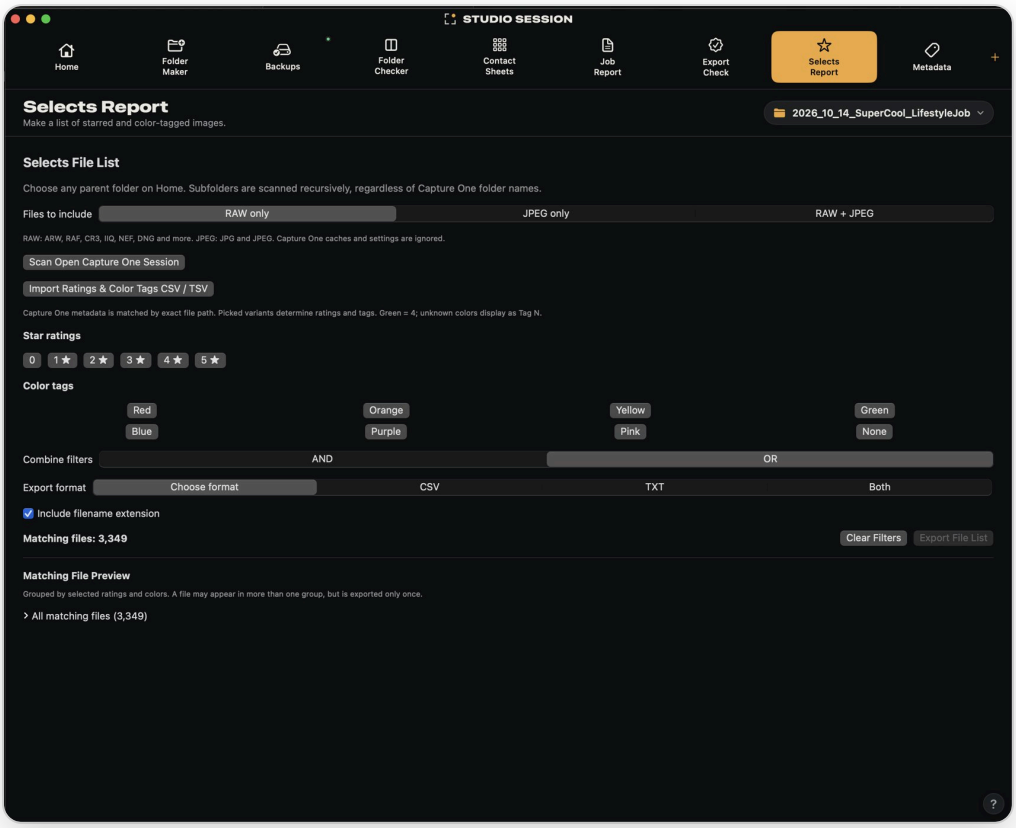
HOW IT MATCHES

JPEGs are matched to raws by base filename. It doesn't judge image quality, and identical names in different subfolders count as one. It only reads.

12 SELECTS REPORT

Selects Report

Make a list of starred and color-tagged images.



Selects Report

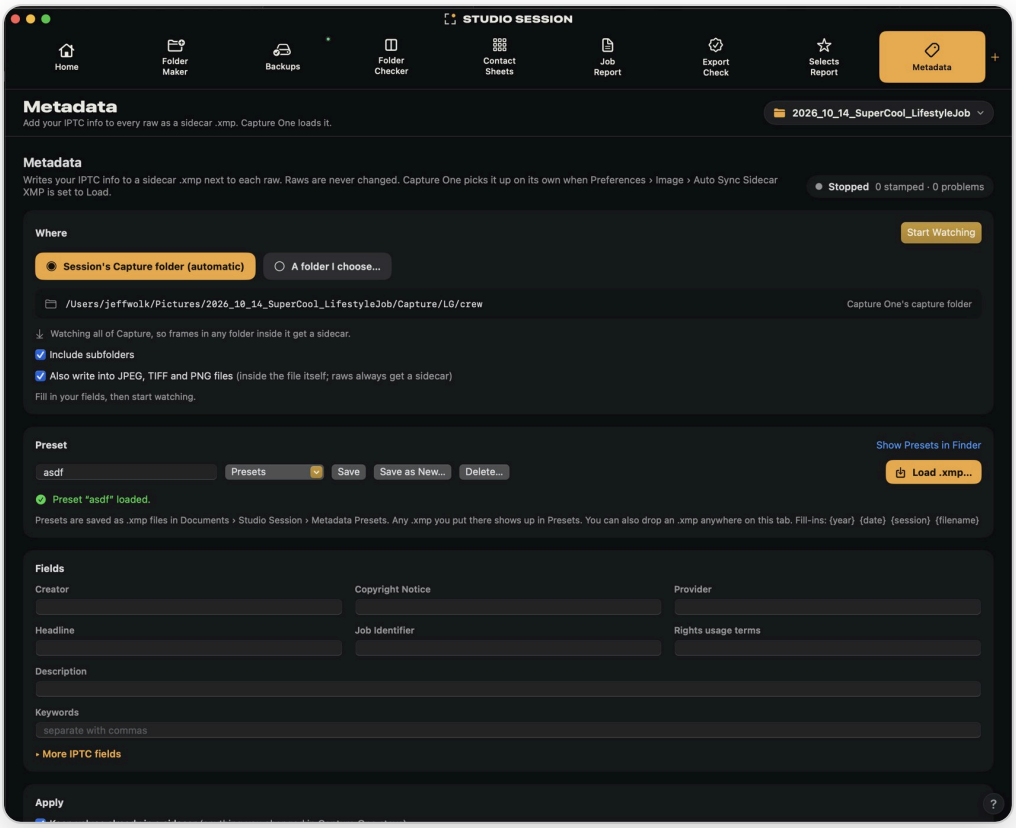
1. Choose **Files to include**: RAW only, JPEG only or RAW + JPEG.
2. With the session open in Capture One, click **Scan Open Capture One Session**. Or import ratings and color tags from a CSV or TSV file.
3. Pick star ratings and color tags. **AND** needs all of them; **OR** needs any.
4. Choose CSV, TXT or both, and whether to include the extension, then click **Export File List**.

- Ratings and tags come from the picked variant in Capture One, matched by exact file path.
- The preview groups matching files by rating and color. A file in more than one group is exported once.
- Studio Session talks only to the Capture One that is already running; it never opens Capture One by itself.

13 METADATA

Metadata

Add your IPTC info to every raw as a sidecar .xmp. Capture One loads it.



Metadata

1. In Capture One, set Preferences › Image › Auto Sync Sidecar XMP to **Load** (once).
2. Fill in the fields (Creator, Copyright Notice, Provider, Headline, Job Identifier, Rights usage terms, Description, Keywords). **More IPTC fields** holds the rest, with Capture One's own names.
3. Under **Where**, keep **Session's Capture folder (automatic)**, or choose a folder.
4. Click **Start Watching**. Each new frame gets its sidecar within a second or two, and Capture One shows the fields.

RAWS ARE NEVER CHANGED

The info goes in a small .xmp file next to each raw, the same way Capture One and Lightroom do it.

- **Follows Capture One:** when you change the capture folder in Capture One, the path updates and that folder is watched.
- **Presets** are .xmp files in Documents › Studio Session › Metadata Presets. **Load .xmp...** loads a client's .xmp into the form; you can also drop one on the tab.
- **Fill-ins:** {year}, {date}, {session} and {filename}.

- **Keep values already in a sidecar:** edits made in Capture One win.
- **Apply to existing frames** stamps frames shot before you started (asks first).
- **Finished images:** turn on **Also write into JPEG, TIFF and PNG files** to write the same info inside exported files too (off by default).
- Watching never starts by itself; click Start Watching each time.

14 WORKFLOW

A shoot day, start to finish

One way to use the tools together.

1. **Before the shoot:** open the session on Home, and build your shot folders in Folder Maker.
2. **Start of the shoot:** fill in Metadata and click Start Watching.
3. **During the shoot:** on Backups, add your drives, pick Quick, and turn on Automatic Backups.
4. **Wrap:** run a Back Up Now with Full verify, then confirm in Folder Checker.
5. **Deliver:** Export Check to catch missed exports, Selects Report for the client list, Contact Sheets and Job Report as PDFs.
6. **Leave:** Eject each drive before unplugging.

15 SETTINGS

Customizing and settings

Make the window yours, and choose how Studio Session talks to you.

- **Switch tools:** click a tab, or press Command-1 to Command-9 in tab order.
- **Rearrange:** drag a tab along the bar. Drag it off the bar to hide it, or right-click and choose Hide. The `+` at the end adds hidden tools back. Navigate › Reset Tool Order puts them back.
- **Menu bar icon:** backup status, Back Up Now, Pause, Resume and Stop while running.
- **Notifications and sounds:** problems always alert you. **Notify When Backups Succeed** and **Sounds** are in the menu bar menu.
- **Updates:** Studio Session checks once a day and only speaks up when there is a new version. **Check for Updates…** is in the app menu.
- **Tour:** the `?` button bottom right shows the tour again.

16 HELP

Troubleshooting

Common messages and what to do about them.

IF YOU SEE	DO THIS
Use This Drive did nothing	Make sure a folder is in the FROM card. Any refusal now explains itself in a dialog.
"Folder names don't match"	The drive's folder holds a backup of something else. Cancel and pick the right folder, unless you meant it.
A drive was held, "Nothing changed"	Many files left the source. Click Review... on the card. Cancel keeps the drive as it is.
Amber "still being written"	Normal while Capture One saves. The next backup catches those files.
Red "couldn't be backed up"	A file can't be read or is locked. The report names it and says how to fix it.
Backup is slower than usual	Check the drive is on a 10 Gb/s port and not nearly full. SSDs slow down after long writes; a rest helps.
Sidecars don't show in Capture One	Set Preferences › Image › Auto Sync Sidecar XMP to Load.

Download the latest version: github.com/WolkPhoto/studio-session-releases/releases/latest